

Grant proposal review report

NIH R01 resubmission · two independent readers · scored under the simplified review framework · factor-by-factor critique, predicted overall impact, and the rewrite list ranked by what each change is worth

This is a redacted sample. It shows the structure and level of detail of a real deliverable. Applicant, institution and project details have been removed or changed. Ask us and we will send one built around an application like yours.

1 How this was read

A mock panel, run the way the real one is run rather than the way an edit is run. Two readers scored the application independently before seeing each other's comments, and the critique below is written in the form a summary statement takes.

Element	How it was handled
Readers	Two. One from the applicant's own field, one from an adjacent field, because a study section contains both and they disagree in predictable ways.
Framework	The simplified review framework, in force for due dates from 25 January 2025: Factor 1 and Factor 2 scored 1–9 in whole numbers, Factor 3 rated rather than scored.
Prior critique	Read first. This is a resubmission, so the earlier summary statement set the questions the new draft has to answer.
Time	Ninety minutes each for a twelve-page Research Strategy, which is roughly what a reviewer carrying eight applications actually gives it.
Reconciliation	Scores compared after both were fixed. Where the readers differed, both positions are reported rather than averaged into one.

What this is not: a prediction of funding. A score describes one panel on one day, and since 2025 institute priorities and strategic considerations sit alongside the score in the decision rather than behind a published payline.

2 The scores

Factor	Score	What it covers, and what the readers concluded
Factor 1 Importance of the Research	3 Excellent	Significance and innovation, scored together. Both readers accepted the premise without argument, which is less common than applicants assume. Neither thought the question was merely incremental.
Factor 2 Rigor and Feasibility	5 Good	The approach. The weakest part of the application, and the only factor on which the readers differed — 5 and 6. Both raised the same underlying problem.
Factor 3 Expertise and Resources	Appropriate	Not scored; reviewers rate it as appropriate or as needing additional expertise or resources. Rated appropriate here, with one written comment on a method that rests on a single collaborator.
Overall impact	4 Very Good	Assigned holistically. NIH instructs reviewers not to average the two scored factors, and tells them the Factor 1 score sets the limit on the best possible overall impact score.

The arithmetic that matters for the rewrite. Factor 1 at 3 caps the overall impact at 3. Repairing the approach moves the overall from 4 to 3 and no further; nothing in the Research Strategy can take it past 3 while Factor 1 stays where it is. That single fact decides what is worth doing in the fortnight available — and it means further work on the significance section would buy nothing, because the writing is not what is holding Factor 1 at 3.

Context the score should be read against: through the October 2026 Advisory Council round, NIH has reduced the share of applications discussed at review to between 30 and 35 per cent, from around half, and sorts the remainder into applications that were competitive but not discussed and those that were not. A score that would have been discussed two years ago may now not be.

3 The critique

What is working, and should survive the rewrite

- **The gap is demonstrated rather than asserted.** The reader from the adjacent field could check the claim from the cited work without taking it on trust, and did. This is what is holding Factor 1 at 3 rather than at 5, and it is the easiest thing to damage while cutting for space.
- **Aim 3 does not depend on Aim 1 succeeding.** Contingent aims are the most common structural weakness in a resubmission, because a reviewer who doubts the first aim then doubts all of them. This draft does not have that problem, and the independence should be made more visible, not less.

What both readers raised independently

- **Aim 2 has no alternative approach.** The assay carrying the primary readout is described once, with no fallback and no decision point at which the team would switch. One reader used the word “fragile”. This is the single largest cost to Factor 2 and the first thing to fix.
- **The power calculation appears as a number.** The effect size it assumes, and the source of that effect size, are not given, so a reviewer cannot check it. One of the two readers did not believe it, and said so in a way that would have appeared in a real critique.
- **One method rests on one person.** The imaging analysis depends entirely on a collaborator with no letter in the application. Factor 3 was still rated appropriate, but the comment will be written, and reviewers are instructed that gaps in expertise or resources should affect the overall score.

Two further comments, from one reader each

- **The third criticism from the previous round is answered in the introduction but not in the Research Strategy.** A reviewer looking for the change will look where the science is, and a new reviewer on the panel may not read the introduction closely at all.
- **Both readers lost the thread on the second background page.** One recovered and one did not. The argument turns out to be sound, which is why this is reported as a writing problem rather than a scientific one — and it is a page that can simply go.

4 The rewrite list

Ranked by what each change is worth rather than by how much work it is, because the fortnight before a deadline is reliably spent on the section the applicant most enjoys rewriting.

Change	Worth
1. Give Aim 2 a stated alternative approach, with the decision point at which the team would switch to it and what would trigger that decision.	Most of the movement in Factor 2
2. Show the power calculation's assumptions: the effect size, where it came from, and why it is the smallest difference worth detecting.	Closes the feasibility doubt
3. Obtain a letter from the imaging collaborator that commits named time, not enthusiasm.	Removes the Factor 3 comment
4. Move the answer to the third earlier criticism into the Research Strategy itself, leaving a pointer in the introduction.	Protects against a new reviewer
5. Cut the second background page.	Buys space for items 1 and 2

Change	Worth
Together	Factor 2 from 5 to 3, and the overall impact from 4 to 3

What is deliberately not on this list. Further work on the significance section. Factor 1 is already at 3, it is the ceiling on the overall score, and the writing is not what is holding it there — so time spent polishing it is time taken from the two changes that do move the score. Telling an applicant to stop working on something is usually the most useful sentence in this document.

Estimated cost of the list: around three days of the principal investigator's attention, plus one letter that needs a fortnight of notice. Item 3 is the one that has to be started today.

5 What is handed over

- The two readers' independent critiques, unedited, with their scores as first recorded.
- The reconciled report: factor-by-factor findings, with the points both readers raised marked.
- The predicted overall impact score, with the reasoning and the ceiling stated explicitly.
- The rewrite list, ranked by score movement, with an estimate of what each change costs in time.
- A compliance check against the funding opportunity: page limits, formatting, mandatory sections and annexes.
- A marked-up copy of the proposal, keyed to the numbered items in the rewrite list.

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